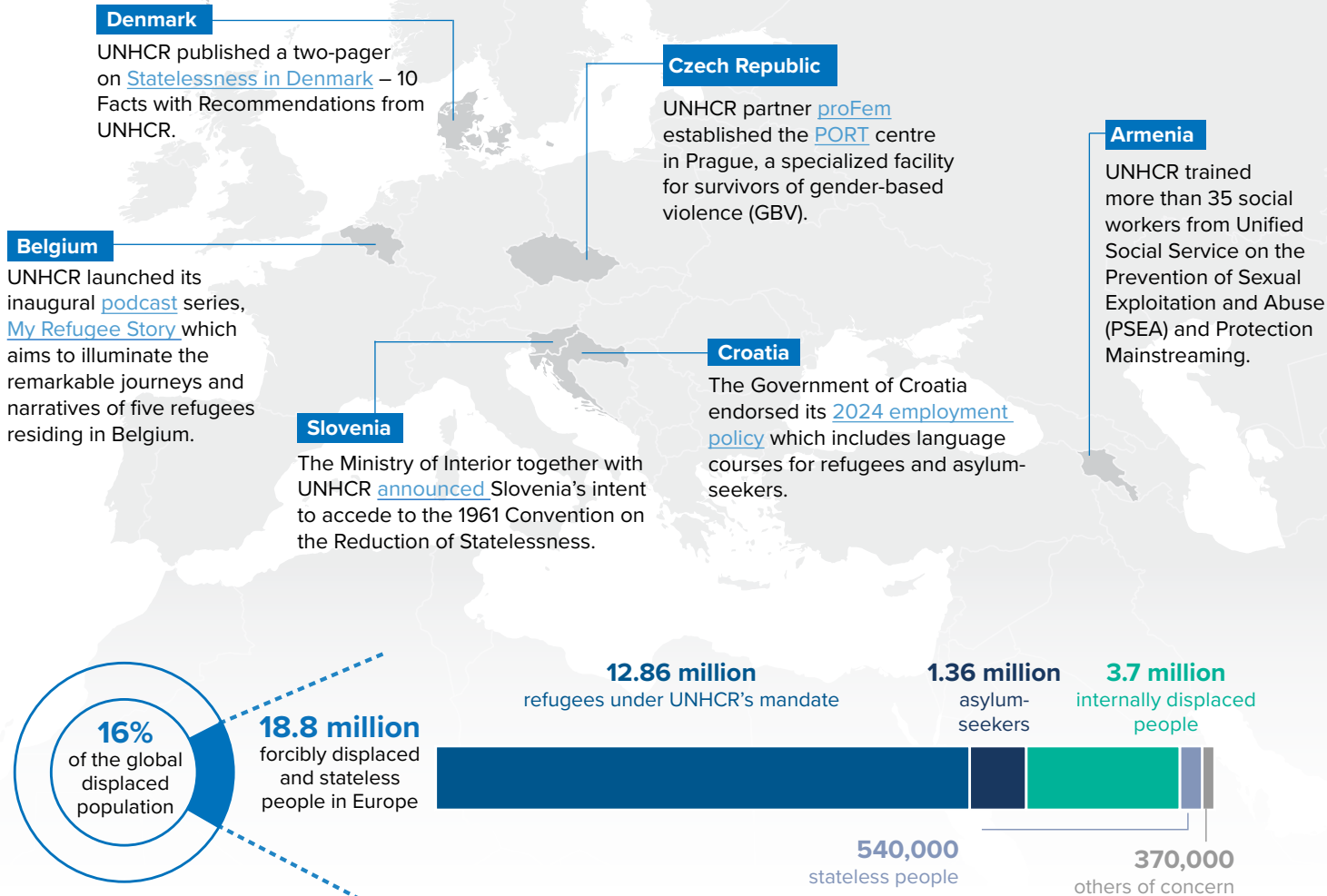


EUROPE AT A GLANCE



Source: UNHCR [data finder platform](#) and mid-year statistics as of 24 October 2023. References to Kosovo shall be understood to be in the context of Security Council Resolution 1244 (1999). The boundaries and names shown, and the designations used on this map do not imply official endorsement or acceptance by the United Nations.

ARRIVALS AND DISPLACED POPULATIONS: KEY FIGURES AND TRENDS IN EUROPE

UKRAINE SITUATION

5.9 million individual refugees from Ukraine had registered across Europe as of end-December 2023¹. An estimated **3.7 million** people were internally displaced within Ukraine².

MEDITERRANEAN AND NORTHWEST AFRICAN MARITIME ROUTES

18,400 refugees and migrants arrived in Europe via the three Mediterranean and Northwest African Maritime Routes in December 2023, nine per cent less than the previous month. As of 31 December, 3,842 people have been reported dead or missing on the three Mediterranean and the Northwest African Maritime Routes. The top three nationalities for sea and land arrivals were Guinea, Côte d'Ivoire and Tunisia.

SOUTH EASTERN EUROPE

600 people have arrived in or transited through the sub-region in December 2023, 72 per cent less than the previous month and 73 per cent less than in December 2022.

TÜRKİYE

Türkiye is among the top refugee hosting countries worldwide, with **3.3 million** Syrians under temporary protection and some 300,000 refugees and asylum-seekers from other countries under international protection.

1. [Operational Date Portal: Ukraine Refugee Situation](#)
2. [IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix](#)



UN High Commissioner for Refugees Filippo Grandi speaks at the closing plenary of the Global Refugee Forum in Geneva. © UNHCR/Jose Cendon

GLOBAL REFUGEE FORUM

- The second Global Refugee Forum (GRF) took place from 13 - 15 December 2023 in Geneva, Switzerland, with linked events held in other locations from 11 December. The 2023 Forum was co-convened by five States (Colombia, France, Japan, Jordan and Uganda) and co-hosted by the Government of Switzerland and UNHCR. The Forum is the world's largest international gathering on refugees, designed to support the practical implementation of the objectives set out in the [Global Compact on Refugees](#). Over 4,200 participants from 168 countries attended, including over 300 refugee delegates.
- The Forum saw over 1,600 [pledges made](#) to support refugees and their host communities, including 43 multi-partner commitments led by governments. An estimated USD 2.2 billion in new financial commitments by States and other actors was announced, including some USD 250 million pledged by the private sector. These outcomes offer a source of hope to the more than 36 million refugees displaced worldwide.
- During a parallel high-level event on 14 December 'Ukraine Refugee Situation – Access to Rights', participants including UNHCR Regional Bureau for Europe Director Philippe Leclerc praised solidarity shown by states, civil society and the private sector for refugees from Ukraine.
- Click [here](#) to read the UN High Commissioner for Refugees Filippo Grandi's closing statements.

UKRAINE RESPONSE

- UNHCR continues to support people in need within Ukraine together with local partners. In mid-December, UNHCR provided support to families affected by missile strikes including through legal counselling and emergency housing repair kits. UNHCR's local partner Right to Protection (R2P) enrolled 777 people for multi-purpose cash assistance, while providing legal assistance to affected populations in Dniproviskyi and Darnytskyi, Kyiv. UNHCR partner Rokada provided 32 families with emergency shelter kits, while survivors were also provided with mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS). Additionally, a new 'integration hub' began operations on 15 December in Rivne, Rivnenska oblast (western Ukraine), offering services such as legal and psychological counselling, employment support, and relocation assistance.

- During December, Ukraine witnessed an escalation in the number of missiles strikes by Russian Federation forces. On 11 December, an air assault injured at least four civilians, damaging power supply lines while leaving approximately 120 homes without power. On 13 December, more than 50 injuries occurred despite air defense systems intercepting all missiles. Damage was also observed across multiple civilian sites, including a children's hospital and kindergarten, prompting temporary evacuations. Odesa faced attacks on 13 December, injuring 11 civilians. In Khersonska oblast (southeast Ukraine), repeated attacks caused two civilian deaths and damage to residential, administrative buildings, and a medical facility. On 20 December, Russian forces targeted facilities, affecting critical supplies for at least three humanitarian organizations in Kherson.

ASYLUM AND PROTECTION

- Armenia:** On 25 December, UNHCR conducted a training on the Prevention of Sexual Exploitation and Abuse (PSEA) and Protection Mainstreaming, which aims to integrate refugee safety into all aspects of humanitarian work for a holistic approach, for more than 35 social workers from Unified Social Service under the Armenian Ministry of Labour and Social Affairs (MLSA). These social workers will be involved in a multi-sectoral needs assessment, led by the MLSA, specifically targeting refugees from Karabakh throughout the country.
- Czech Republic:** In December, UNHCR partner [proFem](#) (Center for Victims of Domestic and Sexual Violence) established the [PORT](#) centre in Prague, a specialized facility for survivors of gender-based violence (GBV). The centre will provide survivors of GBV with comprehensive psychological support, assistance, and short-term emergency accommodation. As part of the collaboration with UNHCR, proFem will conduct training programs for refugee-led and community-based organizations, as well as NGOs working with migrants, refugees and asylum-seekers to address GBV. Additionally, awareness-raising efforts focusing on the needs of the Ukrainian community, including the provision of information and access to proFem's services through an intercultural worker collaborating closely with refugee-led organizations.



UKRAINE

Between 1 January – 31 December 2023, 2,630,000 people inside Ukraine were reached with assistance by UNHCR and partners.

RRP COUNTRIES

Between 1 January – 31 December 2023, over 380,000 refugees from Ukraine were reached with in-person protection services (legal support, accommodation, social protection).



New report: Socio-economic inclusion - good practices across

A new UNHCR report highlights successful pilot initiatives and practical accomplishments of national authorities, NGOs, and RLOs across Europe, which hold the potential to be replicated on a larger scale. The report covers select practices promoting socio-economic inclusion, drawing on examples from the Czech Republic, Georgia, Poland, Republic of Moldova, Romania, and Slovakia. The interventions highlighted illustrate UNHCR's efforts with national authorities, the private sector, NGOs and refugee-led organizations (RLOs) advancing opportunities for refugees to access rights and services and contribute to their host communities. The document draws on UNHCR's Regional Inclusion Strategy for the Ukraine Refugee Response, introduced in February 2023, which outlines tools and approaches to create an inclusive environment, aligned with socio-economic needs and temporary protection frameworks, and is comprised of five strategic objectives. Reflecting on achievements and challenges, UNHCR advocates these reproducible interventions be employed through a whole-of-society model to drive socio-economic inclusion of all refugees by drawing on the good practices identified from the reception of refugees from Ukraine across Europe.



UNHCR supported Ekaterina with cash assistance, which helped her cover essentials when she first arrived in Romania from Ukraine. She has since found work at a bookshop-shared working space in Bucharest.

UNHCR supported Ekaterina with cash assistance, which helped her cover essentials when she first arrived in Romania from Ukraine. She has since found work at a bookshop and shared working space in Bucharest. ©UNHCR/Ioana Epure

INCLUSION

- **Belgium:** On 8 December, UNHCR launched its inaugural [podcast](#) series “[My Refugee Story](#)” which aims to illuminate the remarkable journeys and narratives of five refugees residing in Belgium. The series seeks to humanize the refugee experience by providing a platform for individuals to share their personal stories, hopes, and achievements. Through these accounts, the podcast aspires to cultivate empathy, understanding, and solidarity within the local community while amplifying refugee voices. The first episode features Syrian refugee Abdulazez Dukhan and is available on platforms such as [Spotify](#) and [Apple](#).
- **Croatia:** In December, the Government of Croatia endorsed its [2024 employment policy](#), implemented by the Croatian Employment Service (CES). Following UNHCR’s advocacy, the policy now includes Croatian language courses for refugees under international and temporary protection, as well as asylum-seekers. This marks a significant step toward early integration, providing a sustainable and country-wide voucher system for language learning. The lack of language courses has been a key barrier for refugees and asylum-seekers inclusion in the labour market. UNHCR will continue to monitor the program’s roll-out and impact.
- **The Netherlands (The Kingdom of):** On 20 December, UNHCR organized a roundtable for refugee-led organizations. The focus of the roundtable was to explore ways to enhance refugee engagement among themselves, the Government, and humanitarian organizations. The session included a group discussion with the Inspectorate of Justice and Security, which supervises implementing organisations of the Ministry of Justice and Security, on how to systematically include refugee voices, knowledge and experiences in their work.

STATELESSNESS

- **Denmark:** In December, UNHCR published a two-pager on [Statelessness in Denmark](#) – 10 Facts with Recommendations from UNHCR. The document was shared with government counterparts, partners, and civil society, many of whom responded positively. The document outlines key facts and figures on statelessness in Denmark, with UNHCR’s recommendations calling on Denmark to undertake several key actions and legislative changes to prevent and reduce statelessness within its territory.
- **Slovenia:** On 21 December, the Ministry of Interior together with UNHCR [announced](#) Slovenia’s intent to accede to the 1961 Convention on the Reduction of Statelessness. The coordinated statement emphasizes the significance of this accession in eliminating statelessness, and underscores Slovenia’s commitment to the protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms.



My Refugee Story



Episode 1 Abdulazez

EUROPE MEDIA HIGHLIGHTS

TOP NEWS STORIES

The Independent [20 DEC]

EU agrees landmark deal to curb migration and share asylum seekers

Daily Mail [15 DEC]

UN refugee chief: Gaza refugee crisis must be prevented

France 24 [12 DEC]

'From despair to hope': UN urges leaders to support refugees

Associated Press [8 DEC]

The Olympic Refugee Foundation and Nike To Work Together To Facilitate Access to Sport for Displaced People

CNN [5 DEC]

How to help civilians in Ukraine

PRESS RELEASES, STATEMENTS

Press Release [15 NOV]

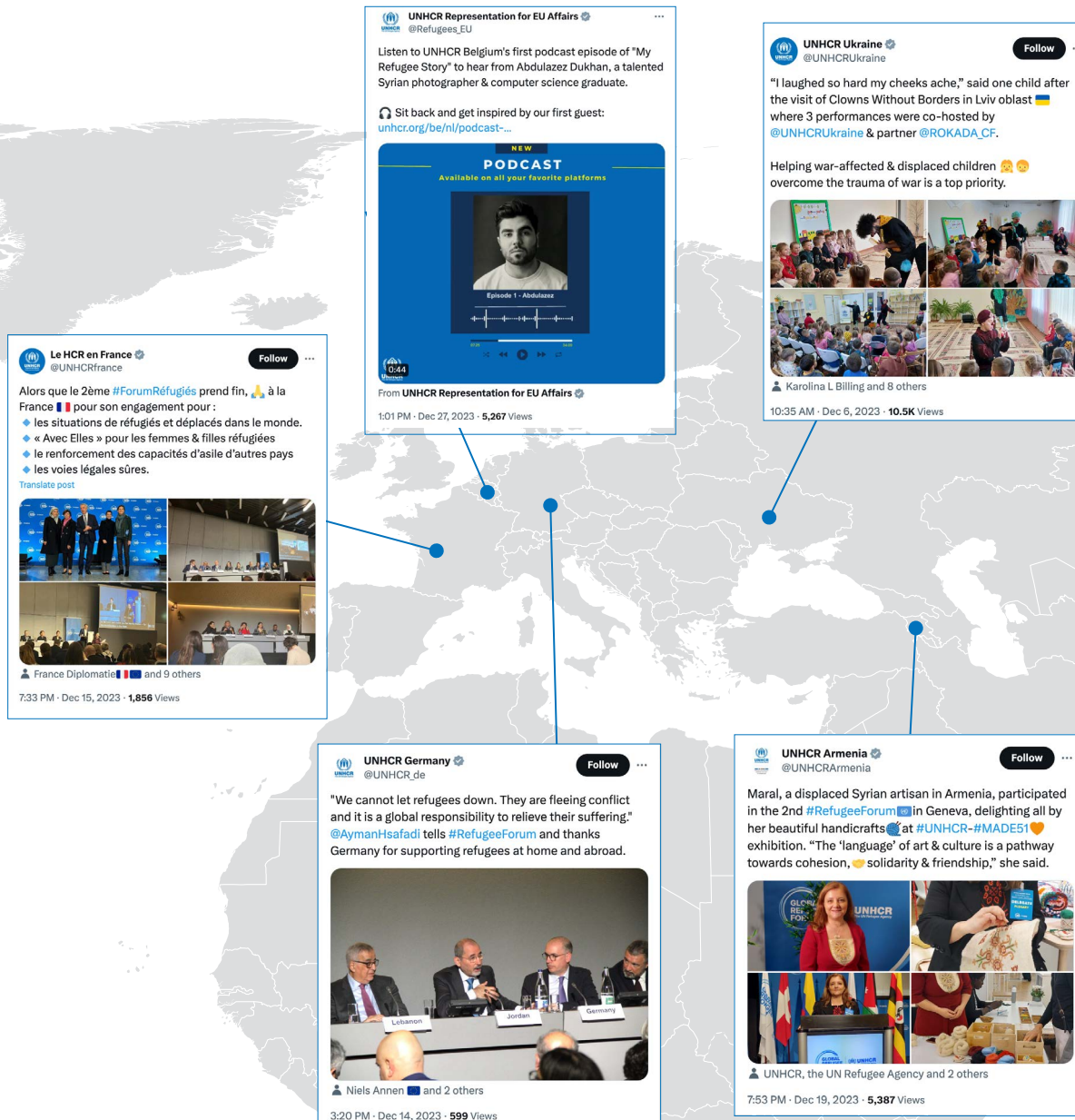
Press Release [8 DEC]

UNHCR Regional Director for Europe concerned about consequences of possible underfunding for those impacted by ongoing war in Ukraine next year

Briefing Note [1 DEC]

As winter sets in, UNHCR calls for sustained support for humanitarian and recovery needs in Ukraine

COUNTRY OFFICE TWITTER HIGHLIGHTS



LEADERSHIP ACCOUNT TWEETS

KChiara Cardoletti, Representative to Italy: New agreement regarding the evacuations of 1500 refugees from Libya. A unique life-saving mechanism in Europe. [20 DEC]

Francesca Bonelli, UNHCR Representative to the Republic of Moldova: Moldova confirmed 9 pledges at Global Refugee Forum [18 DEC]

Gonzalo Vargas Llosa, UNHCR Representative for EU Affairs: The voices of refugees are crucial as we work towards solutions for the uprooted [15 DEC]

Angela Li Rosi, UNHCR Representative to Türkiye: Honoured to present credentials to the Turkish Deputy Minister of Foreign Affairs, Mr. Yasin Ekrem Serim. [6 DEC]

Karolina L. Billing, UNHCR Representative to Ukraine: Life returning to normal in an abnormal world. The determination to recover, revive and rebuild is immense. [1 DEC]

STORY SPOTLIGHT

Empowering Refugee Livelihoods in Albania

A new job coaching program, a collaboration between UNHCR and the local NGO Refugee and Migrant Services in Albania (RMSA), aims to empower refugees in overcoming job search challenges. The program focuses on providing refugees with a comprehensive guidance document covering all aspects of job searching in Albania, complemented by in-person training to enhance their skills. Practitioners supporting refugees also benefit from tools and resources to guide refugees more effectively through the job search process. The guide offers practical information on obtaining work permits, job searching, resume writing, interview preparation, skill development, financial understanding, and insights into local culture in Albania.

NGO practitioners undergo specialized training to enhance their skills in supporting refugees effectively. Artur, a practitioner from RMSA, acknowledged the significant impact of the program, stating that it has made a substantial difference in his ability to confidently assist refugees in their journey to secure employment in Albania. Refugees participating in the program have



Refugees in Albania, along with practitioners from a local NGO partnering with UNHCR, gather to celebrate their accomplishments and display certificates of completion from the job coaching program.

Photo: © UNHCR in Albania

found the guide to be an invaluable resource, serving as their go-to reference for understanding work permits, legal rights, and identifying successful industries. According to Leila, a refugee living in Albania, the guide goes beyond legal aspects and provides guidance on navigating the job market.

For more stories and highlights, [subscribe to our mailing list](#).

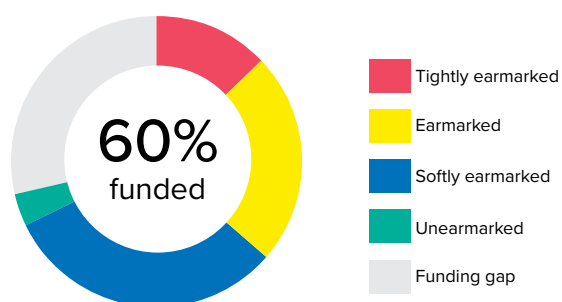
FINANCIAL INFORMATION

Requested for UNHCR's activities in Europe in 2023:

USD 1.694 billion*

Total contributed as of 15 December:

USD 1.221 billion



*This amount includes financial requirements for the Ukraine situation.

WHERE TO FIND

For more information, reports and other resources:

- [UNHCR Europe webpage](#)
- [UNHCR Europe region monthly updates](#)
- [UNHCR Europe country operations fact sheets](#)
- [Europe pages of UNHCR's Global Focus webpage](#)
- [UNHCR Ukraine Emergency webpage](#)

Operational data portals:

- [Ukraine Refugee Situation](#)
- [Mediterranean Situation](#)

UNHCR is grateful for the support from our top government donors of unearmarked, softly earmarked and earmarked funding:

Austria | Belgium | Canada | Czechia | Denmark | European Union | Faroe Islands | Finland | France | Germany | Iceland | Ireland | Italy | Japan | Kuwait | Netherlands | Norway | Spain | Sweden | Switzerland | Republic of Korea | United Kingdom | United States of America

We are also grateful for the generous contributions from private individuals and the private sector.